Mariano Marcos State University
SDG 15 · Life on Land

STORYBOARD · CHAPTER 06 OF 13

06

Sustainable land management for tourism

4 frames

15 LIFE ON LAND

THE STORY

Farm tourism takes shape: rice paddy art, an approved farm-tourism model, a native-tree learning park and a protected-area communication plan.

MMSU'S COMMITMENT

Take an active role in protecting and promoting sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, responsible land use, and biodiversity conservation.

THE FILMSTRIP · 4 FRAMES

2025 Ongoing programme



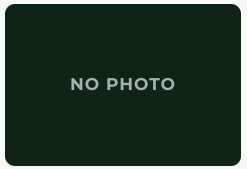
1


DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site

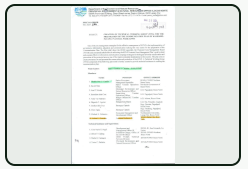
By Wimbledon Bosque

Officials from the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST–PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP–ISSI) conducted a site visit at the Mariano Marcos State University (MMSU) Crops Research Laboratory on January 15 to assess the proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program.

The delegation, led by Assistant Professor Melanie Moroga-Leaño, Director of UP-ISSI and SciCAT Program Leader, together with UP-ISSI extension specialists Kaye Bravo-Cobales, Janelle Faye Tanudtanud, Joshua Garcia, and Garry Nipales, along with Dianne Cabello of the Technology Transfer and Promotion Division, DOST-PCAARRD, was welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius Manzano, Jr.
2



3


4

AT A GLANCE

8th
annual rice paddy art

~50
student guides

2026
TALON approved



Unveiling of the 2025 rice paddy art featuring CHED Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis and her ACHIEVE agenda, MMSU Extension Demonstration Area, 22 August 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)



Rice paddy art featuring Dingras as the Rice Granary of Ilocos Norte, MMSU Dingras Campus, unveiled 9 September 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)

7 JUL – 22 AUG 2025 (BATAC) · 9 SEP 2025 (DINGRAS)

Rice Paddy Art Brings Visitors to MMSU's Farm-Tourism Demonstration Fields

1. **THE ART**
   MMSU and DA-PhilRice held the ceremonial transplanting of the eighth annual rice paddy art on 7 Jul at the Extension Demonstration Area near the Twin Gate, Batac, and unveiled it on 22 Aug.
2. **HOW**
   Made with the PalayCheck System, the Carrageenan Plant Growth Regulator and two varieties, purple rice (IR 1552) and green rice (NSIC Rc222); about 50 BS Agriculture students with extension and research staff served as guides and transplanters.
3. **DINGRAS**
   On 9 Sep the Dingras Campus unveiled its second paddy art with PhilRice Ilocos Norte and LGU Dingras, aligned with RA 10816, the Farm Tourism Development Act.

8th	~50	2
annual paddy art	student guides	campuses

Source: MMSU News, "CHED Chairperson Agrupis to be featured in MMSU-PhilRice paddy art," 8 July 2025 · MMSU News, "2025 Rice Paddy art features CHED Chair Agrupis," 22 August 2025 · MMSU News, "Dingras campus launches rice paddy art," 12 September 2025



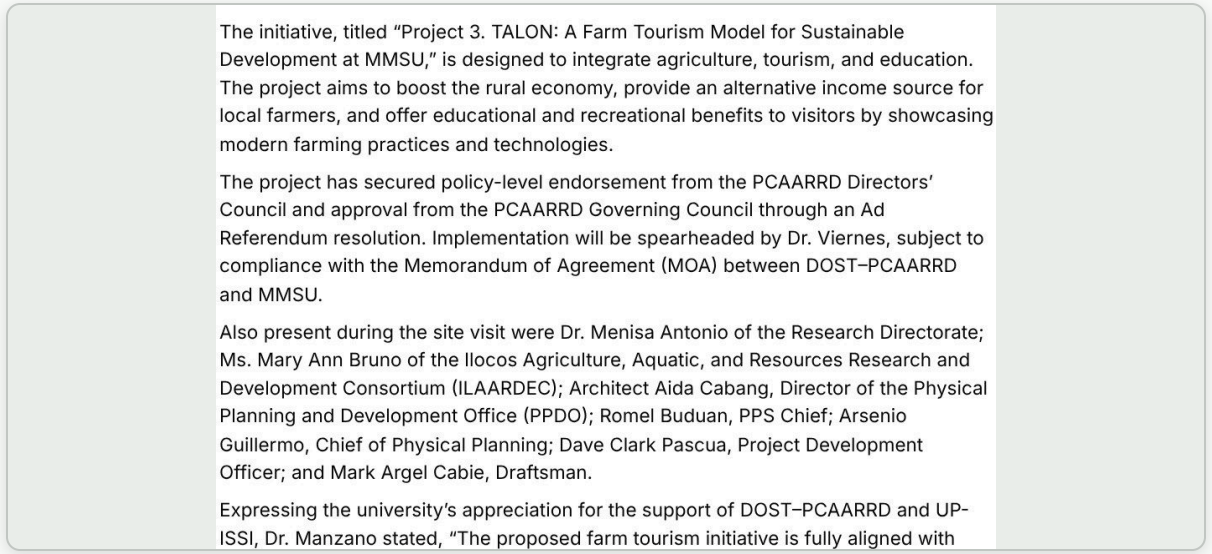
DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site

By Wimbledon Bosque

Officials from the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST–PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP-ISSI) conducted a site visit at the Mariano Marcos State University (MMSU) Crops Research Laboratory on January 15 to assess the proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program.

The delegation, led by Assistant Professor Melanie Moraga-Leaño, Director of UP-ISSI and SciCAT Program Leader, together with UP-ISSI extension specialists Kaye Bravo-Coballes, Janelle Faye Tanudtanud, Joshua Garcia, and Garry Nipales, along with Dianne Cabello of the Technology Transfer and Promotion Division, DOST–PCAARRD, was welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius Manzano, Jr.

Capture: MMSU News, 20 January 2026, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site" (headline and opening paragraphs).



The initiative, titled "Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU," is designed to integrate agriculture, tourism, and education. The project aims to boost the rural economy, provide an alternative income source for local farmers, and offer educational and recreational benefits to visitors by showcasing modern farming practices and technologies.

The project has secured policy-level endorsement from the PCAARRD Directors' Council and approval from the PCAARRD Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution. Implementation will be spearheaded by Dr. Viernes, subject to compliance with the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) between DOST–PCAARRD and MMSU.

Also present during the site visit were Dr. Menisa Antonio of the Research Directorate; Ms. Mary Ann Bruno of the Ilocos Agriculture, Aquatic, and Resources Research and Development Consortium (ILAARDEC); Architect Aida Cabang, Director of the Physical Planning and Development Office (PPDO); Romel Buduan, PPS Chief; Arsenio Guillermo, Chief of Physical Planning; Dave Clark Pascua, Project Development Officer; and Mark Argel Cabie, Draftsman.

Expressing the university's appreciation for the support of DOST–PCAARRD and UP-ISSI, Dr. Manzano stated, "The proposed farm tourism initiative is fully aligned with

Capture: the same article, on Project 3 TALON and the approval of the PCAARRD Governing Council.

15 JAN 2026 · MMSU CROPS RESEARCH LABORATORY

DOST-PCAARRD and UP-ISSI Assess MMSU's Proposed TALON Farm Tourism Project

Ongoing programme · site visit of January 15, 2026

1. **THE VISIT**
   DOST-PCAARRD and UP-ISSI officials, led by SciCAT Program Leader Asst. Prof. Melanie Moraga-Leaño, assessed a proposed MMSU farm tourism project under the SciCAT Expansion Program.
2. **THE PROJECT**
   Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU integrates agriculture, tourism and education, boosting the rural economy and offering alternative income for farmers.
3. **THE STATUS**
   Endorsed by the PCAARRD Directors' Council and approved by the Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution; implementation is led by Dr. Eva Jean Viernes under the DOST-PCAARRD–MMSU MOA.

Jan 2026
site assessment

Source: MMSU News, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site," 20 January 2026

13 Jan 2023 · Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park, Main Campus

28
native tree species

120
seedlings (2023)

2017
Green Wall began

13 JAN 2023 · BIODIVERSITY CONSERVATION LEARNING CENTER AND LEISURE PARK, MAIN CAMPUS

Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park Is Enriched with 28 Native Tree Species

Ongoing programme · since 2023

1. **THE PLANTING**
120 more seedlings of 28 native tree species and two bamboo species were planted, led by then President Shirley C. Agrupis with administrators, faculty, staff and students.

2. **HOW IT IS USED**
A field laboratory for classes, identified for development into a health and wellness tourism hub endorsed by the provincial government.

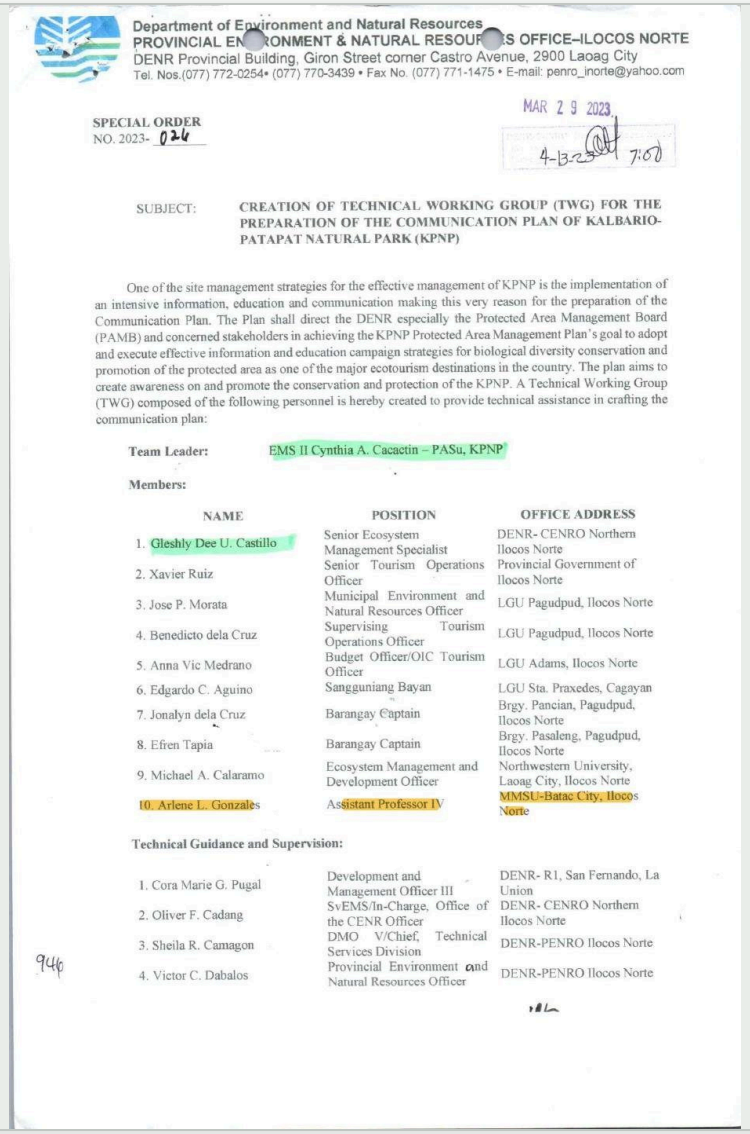
3. **THE TRADITION**
Continues planting begun in 2017 with the Green Wall project on the Batac campus, extending to Nagbacsan, Currimao, Dingras and Laoag, in support of the provincial Green Wall of Ilocos Norte and DENR's National Greening Program.

28
native tree species

120
seedlings (2023)

2017
Green Wall began

Source: MMSU News, "More trees planted at MMSU to establish 'health tourism' hub," 13 January 2023



Department of Environment and Natural Resources
PROVINCIAL ENVIRONMENT & NATURAL RESOURCES OFFICE–ILOCOS NORTE
DENR Provincial Building, Giron Street corner Castro Avenue, 2900 Laoag City
Tel. Nos.(077) 772-0254• (077) 770-3439 • Fax No. (077) 771-1475 • E-mail: penro_inorte@yahoo.com

SPECIAL ORDER
NO. 2023- 024

MAR 2 9 2023

SUBJECT: CREATION OF TECHNICAL WORKING GROUP (TWG) FOR THE PREPARATION OF THE COMMUNICATION PLAN OF KALBARIO-PATAPAT NATURAL PARK (KPNP)

One of the site management strategies for the effective management of KPNP is the implementation of an intensive information, education and communication making this very reason for the preparation of the Communication Plan. The Plan shall direct the DENR especially the Protected Area Management Board (PAMB) and concerned stakeholders in achieving the KPNP Protected Area Management Plan's goal to adopt and execute effective information and education campaign strategies for biological diversity conservation and promotion of the protected area as one of the major ecotourism destinations in the country. The plan aims to create awareness on and promote the conservation and protection of the KPNP. A Technical Working Group (TWG) composed of the following personnel is hereby created to provide technical assistance in crafting the communication plan:

Team Leader: EMS II Cynthia A. Cacactin – PASu, KPNP

Members:

NAME	POSITION	OFFICE ADDRESS
1. Gleshly Dee U. Castillo	Senior Ecosystem Management Specialist	DENR- CENRO Northern Ilocos Norte
2. Xavier Ruiz	Senior Tourism Operations Officer	Provincial Government of Ilocos Norte
3. Jose P. Morata	Municipal Environment and Natural Resources Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
4. Benedicto dela Cruz	Supervising Tourism Operations Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
5. Anna Vic Medrano	Budget Officer/OIC Tourism Officer	LGU Adams, Ilocos Norte
6. Edgardo C. Aguino	Sangguniang Bayan	LGU Sta. Praxedes, Cagayan
7. Jonalyn dela Cruz	Barangay Captain	Brgy. Pancian, Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
8. Efren Tapia	Barangay Captain	Brgy. Pasaleng, Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
9. Michael A. Calaramo	Ecosystem Management and Development Officer	Northwestern University, Laoag City, Ilocos Norte
10. Arlene L. Gonzales	Assistant Professor IV	MMSU-Batac City, Ilocos Norte

Technical Guidance and Supervision:

1. Cora Marie G. Pugal	Development and Management Officer III	DENR- R1, San Fernando, La Union
2. Oliver F. Cadang	SvEMS/In-Charge, Office of the CENR Officer	DENR- CENRO Northern Ilocos Norte
3. Sheila R. Camagon	DMO V/Chief, Technical Services Division	DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte
4. Victor C. Dabalos	Provincial Environment and Natural Resources Officer	DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte

946

Document: DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024 (29 March 2023) naming Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU to the KPNP Technical Working Group.

SPECIAL ORDER NO. 2023-024 · 29 MAR 2023 · DENR-PENRO ILOCOS NORTE

MMSU Expert Serves on the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park Technical Working Group

Ongoing role · appointment of 29 March 2023

1 **THE APPOINTMENT**
Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU was named to the Technical Working Group preparing the Communication Plan of the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park, a protected area in Ilocos Norte.

2 **THE GROUP**
Led by the KPNP Protected Area Superintendent, with DENR offices, the Provincial Government, the LGUs of Pagudpud, Adams and Sta. Praxedes (Cagayan), barangay officials and Northwestern University.

3 **THE GOAL**
To support the Protected Area Management Plan's information and education campaigns for biodiversity conservation and the promotion of the park as a major ecotourism destination.

2023
appointment

3
partner LGUs

Source: DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, 29 March 2023 (MMSU SDG 15 page)

WHERE THE STORY LANDS

Rice paddy art draws visitors to demonstration fields with students as guides. A farm-tourism model, a native-tree park and a role in a natural park's communication plan point the same way: tourism built around agriculture, learning and conservation.

8th	~50	2026
annual rice paddy art	student guides	TALON approved

THE FRAMES

1. **Rice Paddy Art Brings Visitors to MMSU's Farm-Tourism Demonstration Fields**
   7 Jul – 22 Aug 2025 (Batac)
2. **DOST-PCAARRD and UP-ISSI Assess MMSU's Proposed TALON Farm Tourism Project**
   15 Jan 2026
3. **Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park Is Enriched with 28 Native Tree Species**
   13 Jan 2023
4. **MMSU Expert Serves on the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park Technical Working Group**
   Special Order No. 2023-024

SOURCES (6)

1. MMSU News, "CHED Chairperson Agrupis to be featured in MMSU-PhilRice paddy art," 8 July 2025
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2472/ched-chairperson-agrupis-to-be-featured-in-mmsu-philrice-paddy-art
2. MMSU News, "2025 Rice Paddy art features CHED Chair Agrupis," 22 August 2025
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2527/2025-rice-paddy-art-features-ched-chair-agrupis
3. MMSU News, "Dingras campus launches rice paddy art," 12 September 2025
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2560/dingras-campus-launches-rice-paddy-art
4. MMSU News, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site," 20 January 2026
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2869/dost-pcaarrd-up-issi-visit-proposed-mmsu-farm-tourism-project-site
5. MMSU News, "More trees planted at MMSU to establish 'health tourism' hub," 13 January 2023
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/news/more-trees-planted-at-mmsu-to-establish-health-tourism-hub
6. DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, 29 March 2023 (MMSU SDG 15 page)
   https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/resources/1TCpM-DxbkgfOh4QGwlfVr8QavCchKWKu/data